

The Weight of Expectations*

*The Extended Version

All ten works from [Chronicle I](#) are available in the
[AuroraChronicles Books archive](#).

The collection features the following 6 stories:

A Tale of Two Perspectives
A Balanced Life
The Fault Lines
The Needs We Carry
The Weight of Expectations
The Weight of Words

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The Weight of Expectations

Ryan sat in front of the mirror, staring at his reflection. The dark circles under his eyes told a story he couldn't say aloud. Each day felt like a battlefield—fighting unseen wars in his mind, carrying the expectations of a world that demanded too much and gave too little.

Movies and shows painted a picture of the "perfect man"—the strong, stoic protector. Be tough, show no weakness, and handle it all—that's what they always said. His father once told him, "Men don't cry, son. Be a man." Those words had embedded themselves deep, an anchor dragging him down whenever he felt vulnerable.

Yet all Ryan really wanted was peace. Not perfection. Not strength. Just the quiet freedom to be human.

The Unseen Battles

It wasn't just the big expectations that weighed him down. It was the little things—how people said things, how their words cut deeper than they realized.

"Your beard makes you look scruffy," his girlfriend had once said, wrinkling her nose. She didn't know how those words replayed in his head like a broken record. It wasn't what she meant, but it's what he heard: "You're not enough as you are."

Imagine, he thought, if instead she had said, "You look so nice when you're clean-shaven." Same message, different impact. One gave a reason to feel better. The other made him feel like a failure.

"Why don't you ever talk about your problems?" his friends asked, unaware that he spent hours talking to himself, trying to untangle the thoughts in his mind. Would they really listen? Or would they just tell him to 'man up'? He didn't know. So he stayed silent.

Breaking Down

The pressure built slowly—like water filling a dam. Ryan buried himself in work, fitness routines, and mindless scrolling. Anything to distract him from the growing weight of his thoughts.

Then, one day, it happened. He sat in his car after work, staring blankly at the steering wheel. His chest felt heavy, his breaths shallow. It was like a thousand voices whispered in unison:

"Be better. Be stronger. Don't disappoint anyone."

Ryan gripped the wheel, his hands trembling. Why wasn't he enough? He thought of all the expectations—the way he was supposed to look, act, and speak. He realized how much of his life was spent performing, fitting into a role that wasn't his to play.

"I just want to be me," he whispered. It was the first honest thing he had said in weeks.

The Power of Words

Words are strange things, Ryan thought later. They can destroy someone without leaving a mark, or they can rebuild someone who's falling apart.

He remembered what someone once told him: "You always work so hard; I admire that about you." It wasn't a big statement, but it stayed with him. Unlike criticism, it didn't demand change. It acknowledged what he already was.

What if the world said things differently?

Instead of "You're lazy," hearing, "You're so productive when you're focused."

Instead of "Why don't you speak up more?" hearing, "I love hearing your thoughts when you share them."

Instead of "Stop crying, be strong," hearing, "It's okay to feel this way. I'm here for you."

Words could either heal or harm, and Ryan realized how many wounds he carried from careless ones.

Choosing Peace

Ryan knew he couldn't change how the world treated him. But he could change how he treated himself.

He started small. He let himself rest without guilt, shared his thoughts with people he trusted, and stopped treating every difficult feeling as something he had to hide. Strength, he realized, did not always mean holding everything in. Sometimes it meant being honest enough to say that something hurt.

He also became more careful with his words. He knew now how easily a careless sentence could stay with someone. A simple, "You did great today," or "I appreciate you," could mean more than the person saying it might ever know.

He remembered someone once telling him, "You always work so hard. I admire that about you." It hadn't asked him to change. It had simply noticed something good in him. Somehow, that meant more than he expected.

Learning to Be Himself

As Ryan became quieter with himself, he began noticing how much of him had been shaped by the people around him.

Their opinions had influenced what he valued, what he feared, and even what he thought he was supposed to want. Some of those influences had helped him grow. Others had made him feel as though he was always falling short.

He knew he couldn't avoid being shaped by his surroundings. But he could choose what to keep.

He could learn without imitating. He could adapt without disappearing into what others expected him to be.

For the first time, he asked himself a question he had spent years avoiding:

What do I actually want?

He didn't have an answer immediately.

For once, he didn't need one.

What We Choose to Carry

Ryan slowly understood that expectations were not always standards, and they were not automatically the bare minimum. Sometimes, they were simply things people hoped for.

He couldn't make someone understand him, change their behaviour, or give him exactly what he needed. What he could do was be honest with himself about what mattered to him and what he was willing to accept.

He also learned that not everything deserved a reaction.

Someone could be impatient without making him impatient. Someone could be harsh without taking away his kindness. Someone else's way of living did not have to become a measure of his own.

The world would always have something to say.

Ryan was learning that he didn't have to carry all of it.

Becoming Better, Not Different

Ryan still wanted to improve himself. He wanted to work hard, take care of himself, and build a life he could be proud of.

But improvement no longer meant constantly searching for what was wrong with him.

Some days, becoming better meant pushing himself.

Other days, it meant resting.

It meant enjoying the music he loved, making time for the things that gave him joy, and allowing himself to be calm without feeling unproductive. He began to understand that happiness didn't have to wait for a perfect life. It could exist in ordinary moments, right in the middle of everything else.

His surroundings would continue to shape him. People would still disappoint him. Expectations would still exist.

But Ryan could choose what he allowed to change him.

He could become better without becoming someone else.

That evening, he stood in front of the mirror again.

The dark circles were still there. He was still imperfect, still learning, still carrying things he hadn't completely let go of.

But this time, he didn't look at his reflection wondering whether he was enough.

He simply smiled.

For once, he wasn't trying to become someone worth being.

He was simply becoming himself.

Ryan still faced expectations. The world hadn't changed. But he no longer let it destroy him. He chose peace and happiness over the worries and self loathing that the world makes him to do.